

worked hard enough, the possibility of playing for England existed.

Speaking of West Indies cricket today, is there a disconnect between the team and the interest among West Indian kids in Britain?

Yeah, there's a big disconnect. When I was playing, our parents had come from the Caribbean with a very strong cricketing background. They loved the sport in the West Indies. They came to England but still had a love for the sport. They really looked forward to when the West Indies came to England to play cricket and followed the fortunes of the West Indies team, who were very dominant. Those people were empowered to feel proud of being black in a new society.

Now, what really happened with my brothers and sisters, and the brothers and sisters of thousands of others born in England, is that they didn't have the same feel for West Indies cricket because they didn't grow up with it. My mother and father grew up in Barbados, where cricket was everything. It was always there and part of the fabric of being a West Indian. But my siblings grew up in England, where there weren't many black people playing the game at a high level at that time. The only time they felt proud was when the West Indies came to England, and they were very strong then. They were beating the English, and their supporters felt good because they could go to work the next day, lift their heads up, and feel proud.

But the kids — their kids — were English, and their loyalty was really to football. They saw role models in the 1960s involved with football. Another factor was the decline of the West Indies team, which affected the love for cricket among people in England. People stopped associating themselves with West Indies cricket because there was nothing to be proud of anymore.

Also, during the last 15 to 20 years, we saw the rise of cricketers from fee-paying schools. State schools didn't have cricket programmes and struggled for

facilities. You may remember there was a period in the 1980s when successive governments in England, under the Conservatives, were selling off the playing field of schools for housing developments. This reduced the space for kids to play sports. Most West Indian kids went to normal government schools, which had no facilities, no coaches, and no equipment. The love for cricket wasn't there anymore, and they weren't encouraged, so nothing happened with cricket for them.

On the other hand, private schools had fantastic facilities, full-time coaches, all the equipment, and they went on tours. They had everything. So, the players getting into the England team started coming from those big schools. Black cricketers or youngsters interested in cricket just disappeared.

Only recently has Jofra Archer played, but Archer cannot really be considered a British black player because he didn't grow up in England and didn't come through the system here. He was brought in, and that's how he made it. So, he's not a good example. You must look a long way back to players like Michael Carberry (in the 1980s), and



Nostalgic: England batsman Roland Butcher in action on his debut in the third Test match against West Indies in Bridgetown, Barbados — his place of birth — on March 14, 1981. GETTYIMAGES

that was years ago.

Tell us a bit about the African-Caribbean Engagement Programme (ACE).

I'm a patron of ACE. It is a programme designed to give black players the opportunity to play cricket at the highest level. Developed by Ebony Rainford-Brent, a former England player and the Women's Director of Cricket in Surrey, ACE aims to nurture talent often overlooked. In fact, an open day for ACE saw about 100 kids attend, exceeding expectations. Trials revealed such high standards that Surrey signed five players immediately. Remarkably, these kids had no formal club or coach, having only played in the streets, showcasing raw talent. Realising its potential, Surrey decided to support ACE further. I believe that in the next five to 10 years, this programme will reignite opportunities for British-born black players.